TECH HIRING & COMPENSATION BENCHMARK OS

Interview Question Bank

2026 Edition

Structured behavioural and technical questions, scoring rubrics, case prompts and debrief guides for Engineering, Product and Sales.

142
questions with follow-up probes

27
competencies across 5 families

11
design prompts & product cases

1-4
anchored scoring scale

Question IDs (e.g. ENG2.3) match the scorecards and interview loops in Hiring_OS_2026.xlsx.
Process guidance only. Not legal advice: confirm interview rules for each hiring jurisdiction.

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1. How to use this question bank

Structured interviews predict job performance far better than unstructured conversations. Each interviewer owns two or three competencies, asks pre-selected questions from this bank, probes for evidence and scores against the same anchored scale. The scorecards in Hiring_OS_2026.xlsx list which question IDs to use for each stage.

Five rules for every interview

- Prepare: read the scorecard, pick two or three questions for your assigned competencies and decide your probes in advance.
- Ask for real examples: "Tell me about a time..." beats "What would you do if...". Use hypotheticals only for cases and design prompts.
- Probe until you have the full story: Situation, Task, Action and Result (STAR), with the candidate's own role made explicit.
- Take notes on evidence: what they said and did, in their words where possible.
- Score independently within 24 hours, before you see anyone else's feedback.

A 45-minute interview plan

Minutes	Block	Notes
0-5	**Welcome**	Introduce yourself and the format. Set the candidate at ease.
5-35	**Questions**	Two or three questions with deep probing. Depth beats breadth: one fully explored example is worth five shallow ones.
35-42	**Candidate questions**	Answer honestly. Their questions are also signal.
42-45	**Close**	Explain next steps and timing. Do not hint at the outcome.

Scoring scale

Score	Label	Anchor
4	**Strong yes**	Multiple specific, relevant examples. Clearly exceeds the bar for the level. Would raise the team's average.
3	**Yes**	Solid, specific evidence that meets the bar for the level. Minor gaps only.
2	**No**	Thin, generic or mixed evidence. Below the bar for the level, though may suit a lower level.
1	**Strong no**	Clear concern or red flag, or no evidence despite probing.

Score against the bar for the level you are hiring for (L1-L5 in the workbook), not against the best person you have ever worked with.

Probe library

Use these follow-ups with any behavioural question until you have specific, first-person evidence.

Purpose	Follow-up
Specifics	What did you do, specifically? What was your part versus the team's?
Evidence	What was the result? How do you know? Can you give me a number?
Options	What other options did you consider? Why did you reject them?
Conflict	Who disagreed, and why? How did you handle it?

Purpose	Follow-up
Difficulty	What was the hardest part? What nearly went wrong?
Reflection	What would you do differently next time?
Timeline	What happened next? Where is it today?
Scope	How big was this: people, money, users, time?

2. Fair and lawful interviewing

Interview questions must relate to the job. Some topics are protected by anti-discrimination law in most jurisdictions and must never influence a decision, so do not ask about them, even casually over lunch. The table below covers common risks. Laws differ by country, state and city, so confirm the rules with your People team or counsel.

Topics to avoid and what to ask instead

Avoid asking about	Job-related alternative
Age, date of birth, graduation year	Only if legally required: "Can you confirm you meet the minimum age for this role?"
Marital status, children, pregnancy, family plans, childcare	"This role includes one week of on-call in six. Are you able to meet that?"
Religion, religious holidays	"Our core hours are 10:00-16:00 local time. Can you work that schedule?" Accommodations go to the People team.
Nationality, birthplace, accent, native language	"Are you legally authorised to work in [country]? Will you now or in future need sponsorship?"
Health, disability, medical history, sick leave taken	"Can you perform the essential functions of this role, with or without reasonable accommodation?"
Current or past salary (banned in many US states, cities and other countries)	"What are your compensation expectations for this role?" Share the band where required.
Arrests or criminal record	Do not ask in interviews. Use your compliant background-check process after a conditional offer.
Gender identity, sexual orientation	Do not ask.
Political views, union membership	Do not ask.
Military discharge status	"Tell me about any experience relevant to this role, including military service."

Reducing bias in the loop

- Ask every candidate at a stage the same core questions in the same order.
- Score immediately after the interview, independently, before reading anyone else's feedback.
- Write evidence (what the candidate said or did), not adjectives ("smart", "not a fit").
- Replace "culture fit" with "values add": what does this person bring that we lack?
- Use a diverse panel; no single interviewer can veto without evidence against a competency.
- Watch for halo (one strong answer colours everything), similarity, contrast and recency effects.
- Assess the level the candidate is applying for, not the level of the best person you have ever hired.

If a candidate volunteers protected information, do not follow up on it, do not record it, and steer back to the job.

3. Core competencies (all roles)

Use these in every loop. Ownership, Collaboration and Communication are weighted on all three scorecards; Learning & growth and Judgment & integrity are optional extras for roles where they matter most.

CORE1 Ownership

Takes responsibility for outcomes beyond the assigned task, acts without being asked and closes the loop.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Uses "I" for decisions and "we" for credit	- Blames teammates, managers or circumstances
+ Names the cost of stepping up, not only the win	- Cannot name a failure
+ Describes a failure with a concrete change made afterwards	- "I was told to" as the main driver
+ Quotes results with numbers	- Outcome is vague or unknown

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
CORE1.1	What made you apply for this role, and what would make the next two years a success for you?	*What are you moving away from? What would make you turn an offer down?*
CORE1.2	Tell me about a time you owned an outcome that was not formally your responsibility.	*What made you step in? What did it cost you? What happened afterwards?*
CORE1.3	Describe a project that failed or missed its goal while you were accountable for it.	*What warning signs did you see early? What did you change as a result?*
CORE1.4	Tell me about a problem everyone around you had accepted as normal, and what you did about it.	*How did you raise it? Who pushed back? Is the fix still in place?*
CORE1.5	Give an example of a commitment you could not keep. How did you handle it?	*When did you tell people? What did you offer instead?*
CORE1.6	What is something you improved in your last role that nobody asked you to improve?	*How did you measure the improvement? Who else benefited?*

CORE2 Collaboration

Works across people and functions to reach a shared goal; disagrees openly, then commits.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Describes the other side's view fairly + Shows disagree-and-commit in action + Gives credit to specific people + Changed their mind when presented with evidence	- Everyone else is the problem - Contempt for other functions ("sales just doesn't get it") - Avoids conflict entirely - Wins arguments but loses relationships

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
CORE2.1	Tell me about a time you strongly disagreed with a teammate or manager.	*How did you make your case? Did you change your mind? How is the relationship now?*
CORE2.2	Describe a project where you depended on a team with different priorities.	*How did you get alignment? What did you give up to get it?*
CORE2.3	Tell me about critical feedback you received from a peer.	*What did you do with it in the following week?*
CORE2.4	Give an example of helping a colleague succeed at something that did not benefit you directly.	*Why did you do it? What happened?*
CORE2.5	Describe the most difficult person you have worked with productively. What made it work?	*What did you learn about your own style?*
CORE2.6	Tell me about a decision you disagreed with but committed to anyway.	*How did you show commitment? Looking back, who was right?*

CORE3 Communication

Conveys ideas clearly and concisely in speech and writing, adapting to the audience.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Leads with the answer, then supports it + Adjusts depth for the audience without being asked + Checks for understanding + Writes clearly (docs, proposals, emails)	- Rambles or cannot summarise - Hides behind jargon - Becomes defensive when asked to clarify - Same pitch regardless of audience

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
CORE3.1	Walk me through your career in two minutes, focusing on the decisions you made and why.	*Use to test concision. Which decision are you least sure about?*
CORE3.2	Explain a complex topic from your work as if I were a new customer.	*Now explain the same thing to an expert. What changed?*
CORE3.3	Tell me about a time a misunderstanding caused a real problem.	*What did you change in how you communicate afterwards?*
CORE3.4	Describe a piece of writing you produced that changed a decision.	*Who was the audience? How did you structure it? What pushback did you get?*
CORE3.5	Tell me about delivering bad news to a stakeholder or customer.	*How did you prepare? How did they react? What would you do differently?*

CORE4 Learning & growth

Seeks feedback, learns quickly and applies new knowledge. Optional for most loops.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Specific recent learning with a method + Acts on recurring feedback + Comfortable saying "I was wrong"	- Cannot name recent learning - Treats feedback as an attack - Fixed view of their own abilities

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
CORE4.1	What is something you learned in the last six months, and how did you learn it?	*How have you used it since?*
CORE4.2	Tell me about a time you were out of your depth. What did you do in the first two weeks?	*Who did you ask for help?*
CORE4.3	What feedback have you received more than once in your career?	*What are you doing about it now?*
CORE4.4	Describe a belief about your craft that you changed your mind on.	*What evidence changed it?*
CORE4.5	Give a specific example of applying a new idea or tool at work.	*What happened? Would you do it again?*

CORE5 Judgment & integrity

Makes sound decisions with incomplete information and does the right thing when it is costly. Optional.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Explains the reasoning, not only the outcome + Admits mistakes nobody else saw + Knows where their lines are	- Rationalises corner-cutting - Hides mistakes - Decisions driven only by self-interest

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
CORE5.1	Tell me about an important decision you made with incomplete information.	*What would have changed your mind?*
CORE5.2	Describe a situation where you were pressured to cut a corner.	*What did you do? What did it cost?*
CORE5.3	Tell me about a mistake you made that nobody else noticed.	*What did you do about it?*
CORE5.4	Describe a speed-versus-quality trade-off you got wrong.	*What did you learn?*
CORE5.5	Tell me about choosing between what a customer wanted and what was right for the business.	*How did you explain it to them?*

4. Engineering

For software, ML, data, SRE and security engineers. ENG6 applies to Staff (L4) and above. Pair ENG2 prompts and the ENG3 exercise with the rubrics that follow them.

ENG1 Technical depth

Understands the systems they work on from first principles and can reason about trade-offs one level below the surface.

Strong signals

+ Draws architecture confidently and explains why
+ Goes one level deeper when probed
+ Names what would break first at scale
+ Holds reasoned opinions loosely

Red flags

- Buzzwords without depth
- Cannot explain their own project's design choices
- Every answer is "it depends" with no follow-through

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG1.1	Walk me through the most technically challenging system you have built or significantly changed. Draw the architecture.	*Why this design? What breaks first at 10x load? What would you change today?*
ENG1.2	Pick a technology you use every day and explain how it works one level below where most people stop.	*Examples: database indexes, garbage collection, TCP, React reconciliation, container networking.*
ENG1.3	Tell me about a time you chose between two technical approaches. How did you decide?	*What data did you use? Who disagreed? Was it the right call?*
ENG1.4	Describe a performance problem you diagnosed and fixed.	*How did you measure it? What was the root cause? What was the result?*
ENG1.5	What is a technical opinion you hold that many good engineers disagree with?	*What would change your mind?*
ENG1.6	Tell me about learning a new language, framework or domain quickly to deliver something.	*How did you learn? What did you get wrong at first?*

ENG2 System design

Designs systems that meet real requirements: clarifies scope, sizes the problem, starts simple and handles failure.

Strong signals

+ Spends the first 5-10 minutes on requirements
+ Does back-of-envelope sizing
+ Defines API and data model before boxes
+ Deep-dives the genuinely hard part
+ Discusses failure modes and operations unprompted

Red flags

- Jumps straight to a favourite stack
- Ignores data volume or consistency needs
- Cannot adapt when a constraint changes
- Over-engineers for scale nobody asked for

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG2.1	Design a URL shortener handling 10,000 writes/s and 500,000 reads/s.	*ID generation and collisions, caching strategy, analytics pipeline, abuse prevention.*
ENG2.2	Design a notification service that sends email, push and SMS to 50M users with per-user preferences and rate limits.	*Fan-out, queueing, retries and idempotency, provider failover, preference storage.*
ENG2.3	Design a rate limiter for a public API used by thousands of customers across multiple regions.	*Algorithm choice (token bucket, sliding window), distributed counters, fairness, latency overhead.*
ENG2.4	Design the backend for a collaborative document editor with real-time presence.	*Conflict resolution (OT or CRDT), sessions and websockets, persistence, offline edits.*
ENG2.5	Design a metrics ingestion and dashboard pipeline for 1M events/s with 13-month retention.	*Ingestion buffer, aggregation and roll-ups, storage tiers, query patterns, cost.*
ENG2.6	Design a payment ledger for a marketplace that guarantees no money is lost or double-counted.	*Double-entry model, idempotency keys, reconciliation, audit trail, consistency guarantees.*

Running the system design interview (ENG2)

Phase	Time	What good looks like
Requirements & scope	5-10 min	Asks about users, scale, read/write mix, consistency and latency needs; writes them down
Sizing	3-5 min	Back-of-envelope traffic, storage and bandwidth; uses numbers to drive design
API & data model	5-10 min	Defines the key endpoints and entities before drawing boxes
High-level design	10 min	Simple design that works first; explains each component's job
Deep dive	10-15 min	Takes the hardest part deep: hot keys, consistency, fan-out, idempotency
Failure & operations	5 min	Discusses failure modes, monitoring, deploys and rollback unprompted

Level	Calibration
L2	A workable design with prompting; may need help with scale and failure modes.
L3	Drives the conversation; handles scale, data model and failure with light prompting.
L4+	Anticipates operational and organisational concerns, compares alternatives and describes how the design evolves.

ENG3 Code quality & craft

Writes readable, tested, maintainable code and improves the codebase for others.

Strong signals

+ Talks through edge cases unprompted
+ Writes tests at the right level
+ Small, reviewable changes
+ Leaves code better than they found it

Red flags

- No tests or "QA will catch it"
- Clever over clear
- Defensive about review feedback

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG3.1	Show me, or describe, a piece of code you are proud of. What makes it good?	*What would a reviewer criticise? How was it tested?*
ENG3.2	How do you decide what to test and at what level (unit, integration, end-to-end)?	*Give a recent example where you chose not to write a test.*
ENG3.3	Tell me about a code review where you pushed back on a change.	*What was the issue? How did it resolve? How did the author feel?*
ENG3.4	Describe a time you inherited messy code. How did you improve it without stopping delivery?	*How did you decide what to leave alone?*
ENG3.5	What does "done" mean for a change you ship? Walk me through your checklist.	*Monitoring? Docs? Rollback plan? Feature flags?*

Coding / pairing exercise rubric (ENG3)

Use a realistic, job-relevant problem the candidate can solve in 40 minutes in their own editor. Avoid trick puzzles. Allow documentation look-ups, as on the job.

Dimension	Strong (4)	Weak (1-2)
Problem understanding	Asks clarifying questions, restates the problem, identifies edge cases before coding	Starts coding without clarifying; misses obvious edge cases
Correctness	Working solution; tests it with examples; fixes own bugs	Does not run or reason about the code; incorrect output
Code clarity	Readable names, small functions, clear structure	Monolithic, hard to follow, magic values
Testing	Writes or describes meaningful tests including edge cases	No testing mindset
Communication	Thinks out loud, explains trade-offs, takes hints well	Silent or defensive; ignores hints
Adaptability	Handles a changed requirement cleanly	Needs to start over when requirements change

ENG4 Debugging & operational excellence

Investigates systematically, operates what they build and learns from incidents.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Forms and tests hypotheses + Uses logs, metrics and traces deliberately + Writes blameless post-mortems with real follow-ups	- Changes things at random until it works - Blames other teams for incidents - Has never been on call and avoids it

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG4.1	Tell me about the worst production incident you were involved in. Walk through the timeline.	*What was your role? How was it detected? What changed afterwards?*
ENG4.2	Scenario: p99 latency doubled after a deploy but p50 is unchanged. How do you investigate?	*Look for: tail-specific causes such as GC, lock contention, a slow dependency, noisy neighbours, a cache miss path.*
ENG4.3	Describe a bug that took you more than a day to find. What finally cracked it?	*What would have found it faster?*
ENG4.4	How do you decide what to monitor and alert on for a new service?	*How do you avoid alert fatigue? What is an SLO you have owned?*
ENG4.5	Tell me about a time you prevented an incident before it happened.	*How did you spot the risk? How did you convince others it was real?*

ENG5 Delivery & execution

Breaks work into shippable slices, manages risk and delivers on commitments.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Ships incrementally behind flags + Flags risk early with options + Cuts scope deliberately to protect dates	- Big-bang releases - Surprises stakeholders late - Estimates are guesses with no learning loop

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG5.1	Walk me through a project you led from idea to production. How did you break it down?	*What shipped first? What was the riskiest part and how did you de-risk it?*
ENG5.2	Tell me about an estimate you gave that was badly wrong.	*When did you realise? What did you tell people? What do you do differently now?*
ENG5.3	Describe a project where requirements changed midway.	*How did you adapt the plan? What did you push back on?*
ENG5.4	Tell me about cutting scope to hit a date. How did you decide what to cut?	*Who did you involve? What did you add back later?*
ENG5.5	How do you balance tech debt against feature work? Give a specific call you made.	*How did you make the case to product?*

ENG6 Technical leadership (L4+)

Sets technical direction beyond their own team and multiplies the output of others. Use for Staff and above.

Strong signals

+ Direction adopted by other teams
+ Specific mentees who grew
+ Influences through writing and prototypes

Red flags

- Authority by title only
- Hoards the interesting work
- Cannot describe how others adopted their ideas

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
ENG6.1	Tell me about a technical direction you set that other teams adopted. How did you get buy-in?	*Who resisted and why?*
ENG6.2	Describe mentoring an engineer through a significant growth step.	*What did you do specifically? How do you know it worked?*
ENG6.3	Tell me about a design decision you reversed after it was in production.	*How did you communicate the reversal?*
ENG6.4	How have you influenced engineering standards beyond your own team?	*Reviews, testing, architecture, hiring?*
ENG6.5	Describe saying no to a senior stakeholder on technical grounds.	*What alternative did you offer?*

5. Product

For product managers, designers, researchers and data scientists. Cases are marked "Case": run them as 30-40 minute collaborative problems and score the thinking, not the final answer.

PRD1 Product sense & customer insight

Starts from a sharp understanding of users and their problems and designs simple, opinionated solutions.

Strong signals

+ Segments users before solving
+ Prioritises one pain point explicitly
+ Proposes an MVP and success metric
+ Grounds ideas in real customer evidence

Red flags

- Feature lists with no user or problem
- Designs for themselves
- No way to know if it worked

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD1.1	Tell me about a product you love. Who is it for, what problem does it solve and how would you improve it?	*Why that improvement over others? How would you measure it?*
PRD1.2	Walk me through a product decision driven by a customer insight others had missed.	*How did you find it? How did you convince the team?*
PRD1.3	Case: Design a product to help remote teams run better meetings.	*Look for: user segments, a chosen pain, a focused solution, an MVP and metrics.*
PRD1.4	Case: Our onboarding completion rate is 40%. How would you find out why and what to do?	*Funnel analysis, qualitative research, hypotheses, prioritised experiments.*
PRD1.5	Case: Should a B2B project management tool launch a free tier? How would you decide?	*Market, cannibalisation, support cost, conversion assumptions, reversible test design.*
PRD1.6	How do you run discovery? Describe your last five customer conversations and what changed as a result.	*How do you avoid leading questions? Who else joins the calls?*

PRD2 Prioritisation & strategy

Makes explicit trade-offs, connects the roadmap to strategy and says no with reasons.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Uses a clear framework and knows its limits + Names what they chose not to do + Strategy fits in two sentences	- Everything is P0 - Strategy equals the backlog - Prioritises by loudest stakeholder

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD2.1	Walk me through how you built your last roadmap. What did you choose not to do?	*How did you communicate the no's?*
PRD2.2	Tell me about a time you killed a project or feature.	*What signal made you decide? How did the team react?*
PRD2.3	What is the strategy of your current product area in two sentences? How does it beat competitors?	*What would make it wrong?*
PRD2.4	You have capacity for one of: a top customer's request, a reliability investment, or a growth experiment. How do you decide?	*What information would you want? Who do you involve?*
PRD2.5	Tell me about a bet you made that did not pay off.	*What did you learn about how you make bets?*
PRD2.6	How do you balance short-term revenue requests with long-term product vision?	*Give a concrete example.*

PRD3 Execution & delivery

Turns plans into shipped product: crisp specs, early de-risking and iterative releases.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Specs state the problem, scope and non-goals + Handles launches and rollbacks calmly + Keeps the team unblocked	- Throws specs over the wall - No plan for launch issues - Ships and moves on without measuring

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD3.1	Walk me through the spec for something you shipped recently. What was deliberately left out?	*Who reviewed it?*
PRD3.2	Tell me about a launch that went wrong. What did you do in the first 48 hours?	*What changed in your launch process?*
PRD3.3	Describe how you work with engineering and design day to day.	*Which rituals do you run? Which did you drop and why?*
PRD3.4	Tell me about a time a project was slipping. How did you get it back on track?	*What did you cut or change?*
PRD3.5	How do you decide when something is ready to ship?	*Give an example where you shipped earlier than the team wanted.*

PRD4 Data & experimentation

Defines metrics before building, reads data correctly and designs sound experiments.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Chooses metrics with a clear rationale + Investigates drops systematically + Understands significance, power and novelty effects	- Vanity metrics - Ships on a noisy three-day test - Ignores qualitative signal

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD4.1	What metrics did you own in your last role? Why those?	*Which one would you change, and why?*
PRD4.2	Case: Daily active users dropped 8% week over week. Walk me through your investigation.	*Look for: data validity, segmentation (platform, region, cohort), external events, recent releases.*
PRD4.3	Tell me about an A/B test whose result surprised you.	*What did you do with the result?*
PRD4.4	Case: A test shows +3% conversion at p = 0.04 after three days. The team wants to ship. What do you ask?	*Sample size and power, novelty effect, guardrail metrics, multiple comparisons, weekly seasonality.*
PRD4.5	How would you measure success for a feature with no direct revenue impact, such as accessibility settings?	*Leading versus lagging indicators.*
PRD4.6	Describe a time data and customer feedback pointed in different directions.	*What did you do?*

PRD5 Technical fluency

Understands architecture well enough to shape scope and trade-offs with engineers.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Explains system constraints plainly + Respects engineering judgment while challenging scope + Knows build/buy trade-offs	- Treats engineering as a black box - Dictates solutions - Surprised by technical constraints late

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD5.1	Explain the architecture of a product you worked on and where the hardest constraints were.	*How did that shape the roadmap?*
PRD5.2	Tell me about a time an engineering constraint changed your product plan.	*What did you change? What did you keep?*
PRD5.3	How do you participate in technical design discussions without overstepping?	*Give an example.*
PRD5.4	Describe a build, buy or partner decision you were part of.	*What criteria did you use? Was it right?*

PRD6 Stakeholder influence

Aligns leaders, peers and customers without formal authority and handles conflict constructively.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Changed a senior leader's mind with evidence + Resolves cross-team conflict + Says no to important customers well	- Escalates everything - Avoids conflict - Over-promises to keep people happy

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
PRD6.1	Tell me about a time you got a senior leader to change their mind.	*What evidence did you bring? What would you do if it had failed?*
PRD6.2	Describe a conflict between sales and engineering over the roadmap. How did you resolve it?	*Who was unhappy at the end?*
PRD6.3	Tell me about a time you had to say no to an important customer.	*How did you keep the relationship?*
PRD6.4	How do you keep stakeholders informed? Give an example of a communication that went poorly.	*What did you change?*
PRD6.5	Describe aligning multiple teams around a shared goal without formal authority.	*What mechanism did you use?*

6. Sales

For SDRs, account executives, sales engineers, customer success and sales managers. Always verify claimed attainment through references or documentation before an offer.

SLS1 Prospecting & pipeline generation

Builds pipeline through a repeatable system rather than relying on inbound luck.

Strong signals

+ Knows their numbers (activity, conversion, sources)
+ Targeted, researched outreach
+ Has a plan for thin quarters

Red flags

- Relies only on inbound
- Cannot quote attainment or pipeline sources
- Spray-and-pray outreach

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS1.1	Walk me through your last four quarters: quota, attainment and how your pipeline was sourced.	*Inbound, outbound, partner, expansion split? Can a reference confirm these numbers?*
SLS1.2	Describe your weekly prospecting system.	*How many touches, which channels, how do you choose accounts?*
SLS1.3	Describe the best cold outreach you sent recently. Why did it work?	*What was the reply rate on that sequence?*
SLS1.4	Tell me about the largest deal you sourced yourself. How did you get the first meeting?	*How long from first touch to meeting?*
SLS1.5	How do you research an account before reaching out? Show me with one of our target customers.	*What would your first line be?*
SLS1.6	What do you do when your pipeline is thin with six weeks left in the quarter?	*What did you do the last time it happened?*

SLS2 Discovery & qualification

Uncovers pain, business impact and the decision process before pitching, and disqualifies early.

Strong signals

+ Asks open questions and listens
+ Quantifies impact with the buyer
+ Maps the decision process and economic buyer
+ Comfortable walking away

Red flags

- Pitches in the first five minutes
- Happy ears: every deal is real
- Never disqualifies

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS2.1	What do you need to know by the end of a first discovery call to keep pursuing a deal?	*Which of those do you most often miss?*
SLS2.2	Tell me about a deal you disqualified early. How did you know?	*What did it save you?*
SLS2.3	Walk me through how you uncover and quantify the business impact of a problem with a buyer.	*Give a real number from a deal.*
SLS2.4	How do you identify the economic buyer and decision process when your contact is not the decision maker?	*What do you do if your contact blocks access?*
SLS2.5	Describe a time discovery changed what you ended up selling.	*How did the deal end?*
SLS2.6	Mock discovery call: run the role-play using the brief in this guide.	*Score with the role-play rubric.*

Mock discovery call brief (SLS2.6)

The candidate is an Account Executive at FlowDesk, a fictional workflow automation platform. The interviewer plays the Head of Operations at a 400-person logistics company. The call is a 30-minute first discovery meeting booked from an outbound email.

Hidden information (interviewer only)

- Order exceptions (address errors, missing customs data) are handled manually by about six full-time staff.
- A top-five customer left last quarter, citing slow exception handling. This is the real pain.
- The CFO must approve any purchase over USD 50,000. The buyer has not involved the CFO yet.
- The team is also looking at one competitor and an internal build option proposed by IT.
- Budget is available next quarter if a business case is approved by the end of this month.

Interviewer instructions

- Reveal hidden information only when the candidate asks a good open question that earns it.
- At about minute 15, object: "Honestly, this seems like something our IT team could build."
- If the candidate starts pitching features before minute 10, become slightly less engaged.
- End the call when the candidate proposes next steps, or at 30 minutes.

Dimension	What a 4 looks like	Score 1-4
Opening & agenda	Sets an agenda, confirms time, earns the right to ask questions	
Pain discovery	Finds the lost-customer pain through layered questions, not a checklist	
Impact quantified	Puts a number on cost (headcount, revenue at risk) with the buyer	
Decision process	Uncovers the CFO approval, the competing options and the timeline	
Objection handling	Explores the build option with curiosity before responding	
Next steps	Secures a specific next meeting that includes the economic buyer	

SLS3 Deal management & closing

Runs disciplined deal cycles: multithreads, builds mutual close plans and protects value.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Multiple stakeholders engaged + Mutual close plans with dates + Knows why they won and why they lost	- Single-threaded deals - Discounts to close - Cannot explain losses beyond price

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS3.1	Walk me through a recent closed-won deal from first touch to signature.	*Who were the stakeholders? What nearly killed it?*
SLS3.2	Now walk me through a closed-lost deal you should have won.	*What would you do differently?*
SLS3.3	How do you multithread an account? Give an example where it saved a deal.	*How early do you start?*
SLS3.4	Tell me about a mutual close plan you built with a buyer.	*Who owned which steps? Did the dates hold?*
SLS3.5	Describe a deal that stalled in procurement or legal. What did you do?	*How did you keep momentum?*
SLS3.6	How do you handle a champion who leaves mid-deal?	*Real example?*

SLS4 Forecasting & CRM discipline

Forecasts on evidence, keeps the pipeline clean and escalates slips early.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Knows forecast accuracy + Clear evidence standard for commit + Tells the manager early when deals slip	- Hope-based forecasting - Stale CRM - Sandbagging or over-committing every quarter

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS4.1	How accurate was your forecast last quarter versus commit? Why?	*What did you learn?*
SLS4.2	What evidence must exist before you put a deal in commit?	*Have you ever broken that rule?*
SLS4.3	Walk me through how you inspect your own pipeline each week.	*What do you look for first?*
SLS4.4	Tell me about a deal that slipped. When did you know, and when did you tell your manager?	*What would you do differently?*

SLS5 Objection handling & negotiation

Stays curious under pressure, reframes on value and trades rather than gives.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Asks questions before answering objections + Trades concessions for commitments + Holds price with confidence	- Caves on price immediately - Argues with the buyer - Uses discounts as the first lever

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS5.1	What is the most common objection you hear, and how do you handle it?	*Show me how you would respond right now.*
SLS5.2	A buyer says your competitor is 30% cheaper. What do you do?	*What questions do you ask first?*
SLS5.3	Tell me about a negotiation where you protected price. What did you trade?	*What did the buyer give in return?*
SLS5.4	Describe a deal you lost on price. Was it really price?	*What was the real reason?*
SLS5.5	How do you handle "we need to think about it" at the end of a demo?	*What next step do you ask for?*

SLS6 Resilience & coachability

Learns from losses, seeks feedback and applies it quickly.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Owns bad quarters without excuses + Specific coaching that changed results + Visible improvement after in-round feedback	- Blames territory, product or leads - Dismisses feedback - No change after coaching in the interview

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
SLS6.1	Tell me about your toughest quarter. What happened and what did you do?	*What did you change for the next quarter?*
SLS6.2	What is the best coaching you have received in sales, and how did it change your results?	*Give a number.*
SLS6.3	Tell me about a time a manager's feedback was hard to hear.	*What did you do with it?*
SLS6.4	How do you stay motivated after losing a big deal?	*What did you do the day after the last one?*
SLS6.5	In-round coaching test: after the mock call, give one piece of feedback and ask the candidate to rerun the first two minutes.	*Score the size and speed of the change, not perfection.*

Reference check guide

Run two references for every sales finalist, and for senior hires in any family, with the candidate's consent. Ask open questions and listen for hesitation.

- How did you work with [Candidate], and for how long?
- What were they best at? Where did they grow the most while you worked together?
- How did their results compare with the rest of the team? (Ask for attainment for sales roles.)
- Tell me about a time they received tough feedback. What did they do with it?
- What would you most want their next manager to know to help them succeed?
- If you had the chance, would you hire them again? Why or why not?

7. Leadership (manager roles)

Add LDR competencies to any scorecard for manager roles (Engineering Manager, Group PM, Sales Manager and above). Set their weights on the scorecard and rebalance the others so the total is 100%.

LDR1 People leadership

Grows people, gives direct feedback and builds a team others want to join. For manager roles.

Strong signals

+ Named people who grew, with specifics
+ Hard feedback delivered with care
+ Handles underperformance decisively and fairly

Red flags

- Takes credit for the team's work
- Avoids hard conversations
- High regretted attrition with no insight

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
LDR1.1	Tell me about someone you managed who grew significantly. What did you do specifically?	*Where are they now?*
LDR1.2	Describe the hardest piece of feedback you have given a direct report.	*How did you prepare? How did they respond?*
LDR1.3	Tell me about managing out an underperformer.	*How long did it take? What would you do sooner?*
LDR1.4	How do you run 1:1s? What changed in your approach over the last year?	*What does a great 1:1 look like?*
LDR1.5	Tell me about a time your team's morale dropped. What did you do?	*How did you know it had recovered?*
LDR1.6	How do you balance staying close to the work with letting your team own it?	*Where did you get it wrong?*

LDR2 Hiring & team building

Defines the bar, raises it with each hire and closes strong candidates.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Clear bar defined before interviewing + Owns and learns from hiring mistakes + Builds diverse teams deliberately	- Hires for comfort or similarity - Vague on how they assess candidates - Leaves closing to recruiting

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
LDR2.1	Walk me through the best hire you have made. How did you find and close them?	*What almost made you miss them?*
LDR2.2	Tell me about a hiring mistake. What did you miss and what did you change?	*How quickly did you act?*
LDR2.3	How do you define the bar for a role before interviewing?	*Show me a scorecard you wrote.*
LDR2.4	How have you built diversity of background and thought on a team?	*What specifically did you change in your process?*
LDR2.5	Tell me about closing a candidate who had a stronger competing offer.	*What made the difference?*

LDR3 Performance & accountability

Sets clear goals, holds the team to them and responds well when they are missed.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Goals are measurable and understood + Owns misses upward + Fair, calibrated reviews	- Goals are activity lists - Blames the team upward - Avoids differentiation in reviews

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
LDR3.1	How do you set goals for your team? Give an example of a goal you got wrong.	*How did you correct it?*
LDR3.2	Tell me about a time your team missed a major commitment.	*How did you respond upward and downward?*
LDR3.3	How do you handle a high performer who is difficult to work with?	*Real example?*
LDR3.4	Describe how you run performance reviews and calibration.	*How do you handle disagreement in calibration?*

LDR4 Strategy & org design

Shapes the team's structure and direction to match the company's strategy.

Strong signals	Red flags
+ Restructures with a clear rationale + Prioritises headcount against strategy + Leads through change with transparency	- Org charts as status - Headcount requests without a business case - Disappears during hard change

ID	Question	Follow-up probes / what to look for
LDR4.1	Tell me about a time you restructured a team. Why, and how did it go?	*What would you do differently?*
LDR4.2	How do you decide headcount priorities with a fixed budget?	*Walk me through a real trade-off.*
LDR4.3	Describe a strategy you set for your org and how you communicated it.	*How did you know people understood it?*
LDR4.4	Tell me about leading through a major change such as a reorg, pivot or layoff.	*What did you tell your team, and when?*

8. Feedback, debrief and candidate experience

Written feedback template

Section	What to write
Overall recommendation	Strong yes / Yes / No / Strong no, with one sentence on why
Scores by competency	1-4 for each competency you were assigned on the scorecard
Evidence	Two to four quotes or observed behaviours per competency
Concerns	Specific gaps against the bar, and how confident you are
Level assessment	Is the evidence at, above or below the target level?
Open questions	What should the debrief or later interviewers probe?

Running the debrief

- All written feedback is submitted before the debrief starts. No feedback, no vote.
- The hiring manager facilitates; the recruiter keeps time and records the decision on the scorecard.
- Start with two minutes of silent reading of all feedback.
- Go competency by competency, not interviewer by interviewer. The most junior interviewer speaks first.
- Discuss evidence. When someone says "I just didn't get a good feeling", ask what the candidate said or did.
- Decide: hire, no hire, or one targeted follow-up interview (never a whole new loop).
- Record the weighted score, must-haves and decision in the workbook. One owner contacts the candidate within 24 hours.

Candidate experience checklist

- Send the loop agenda, interviewer names and format at least two business days in advance.
- Start on time; leave five minutes for the candidate's questions in every interview.
- Give every finalist a decision within two business days of the final interview.
- Share the salary band at the first screen, and wherever local pay-transparency law requires it.
- Send rejected finalists a personal note with one or two pieces of useful feedback where policy allows.
- Ask every candidate (hired or not) for anonymous feedback on the process.

This guide is process guidance for structured hiring. It is not legal advice. Employment, privacy and pay-transparency rules vary by jurisdiction; have counsel review your process for each country you hire in.